Soviet leaders gathered in the Kremlin in anticipation of Kennedy's announced speech on Cuba, Minister of Defense Rodion Malinovsky ordered Pliev to "undertake urgent measures to increase combat readiness and to repel the enemy by joint efforts of the Cuban army and all units of Soviet troops, excluding the weapons of Statsenko and all of Beloborodov's cargo." This meant that Pliev was authorized to use all non-nuclear-tipped weapons, including the surface-to-air missiles of the air defense units. The caveat was that he could do so only to "repel the enemy."[6]

For the moment, all they could do was wait for an American attack. But with American planes in the air, Cubans firing, and rumors of imminent invasion spreading like wildfire, Soviet commanders found the line between impending and actual attack becoming blurred.

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AS KHRUSHCHEV SENT KENNEDY ONE LETTER AND THEN another, looking for a way out of the Cuban nightmare, and Kennedy argued with his aides over the proposed missile swap in order to make an invasion of Cuba unnecessary, Soviet officers and soldiers on the island were living in a world of their own, unaware of the diplomatic moves at the highest levels. They were preparing to resist an invasion, and their main concern was to meet deadlines for deployment of the missiles on the island.

The commander of the 51st Missile Division, General Igor Statsenko, some of whose installations had been discovered and photographed by US overflights, as Pliev had reported to Moscow, had every reason to be proud of what he had accomplished. On September 8, the General Staff had ordered Statsenko to prepare the two regiments with medium-range R-12 missiles for combat by November 1. The regiments armed with intermediate-range R-14s were to be made battle-ready in November and December. Most of the missiles, men, and equipment of the intermediate-missile regiments were still en route to Cuba at the time of Kennedy's announcement and had to be turned back. But three medium-range missile regiments and a good part of the fourth regiment were already on the island,